

From Eclipse & FTP to Agentic Engineering Excellence

A personal learning roadmap — Christian Zander, June 2026

This roadmap uses your existing RPG documentation project (Java / XML / XSLT) as the vehicle to incrementally learn three things: a modern dev toolchain, full-stack web development, and AI agentic engineering. Each phase ships something real before the next begins.

PHASE 1 Foundation

Weeks 1–2

Goal: Move the project into git, push to GitHub, add basic Java quality gates.

Tools: Git, GitHub, Maven or Gradle, Checkstyle or Spotless

You'll learn:

- Version control discipline and pull request workflow
- Automated checks that run on every commit
- How to enforce quality without relying on memory

PHASE 2 Automation

Weeks 3–5

Goal: Build a CI/CD pipeline that compiles and checks quality on every push.

Tools: GitHub Actions, Maven/Gradle, Checkstyle, JUnit

You'll learn:

- CI/CD fundamentals — pipelines as code
- Quality gates that block bad changes automatically
- How automated systems replace manual checklists

PHASE 3 Modernise the App

Weeks 6–10

Goal: Add a REST API over the XML data and a lightweight web UI to manage heroes, monsters, locations.

Tools: Spring Boot (Java), HTMX or vanilla HTML/JS

You'll learn:

- REST API design and JSON over XML boundaries
- Separating data, logic, and presentation cleanly
- Deploying a backend app vs. static files

PHASE 4

Agentic Layer

Ongoing

Goal: Use Claude Code deliberately as an AI engineering partner to scaffold, review, and improve code.

Tools: Claude Code (already installed), GitHub Actions AI review

You'll learn:

- How to write effective prompts for code tasks
- When to trust AI output vs. when to push back
- Structuring tasks so an AI agent can execute them

Key Principles

Everything in git — No more FTP-and-pray. Every change is tracked, reversible, and reviewable.

Quality is automated — Linters and tests run on every change — not just when you remember.

Small steps — Each phase ships something real and useful before the next phase begins.

Open source only — Git, GitHub (free tier), Maven, Spring Boot, GitHub Actions — no lock-in.

Learn by doing — The RPG project is real work. You're not learning on toy examples.

Next step: bring the existing project onto this machine, then start Phase 1.